



Crossing the dark

Crises are not only illness. Sometimes they are a passage.

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*This ebook addresses sensitive topics.
It does NOT replace therapeutic
support. If you are in acute distress or
having thoughts of giving up, please
seek immediate help.*

1. The bottom of the well

There is a place no one wants to go. A place that isn't chosen, isn't planned, isn't anticipated. A place that appears when life breaks in a way you didn't know it could break.

Perhaps you arrived there suddenly. A phone call, a piece of news, a door that closed forever. A loss that tore the ground from beneath you and left you falling, with nothing to hold onto, not knowing where the bottom was.

Or perhaps you arrived slowly. So slowly you didn't even notice. Day after day, the weight increased, the color faded, the air grew harder to breathe. And one day you looked around and realized you were in the dark. You didn't know when it had started. You didn't know how you had gotten there. You only knew you were there.

The bottom of the well has many forms. For some it's the grief that doesn't end. For others it's the exhaustion that reached its limit. For others it's the relationship that fell apart, the identity that crumbled, the body that fell ill, the meaning that disappeared. For some it's all of that

at once. And for others it's none of those things in particular, but an interior collapse that has no name, no visible cause, that fits into none of the categories others can understand.

"But you have everything." "But nothing serious happened." "But look at everything you've achieved." These phrases, said with good intentions, are stones falling on someone already on the ground. Because they suggest that suffering needs justification. That you can only truly suffer when the reason is big enough. That the pain you feel, if it has no visible label, is weakness, drama, or ingratitude.

It isn't. The pain you feel is real. And the place where you are, however dark, is real.

I know that darkness. Not only through training. Not only through accompanying women who have crossed it. I know it because I lived it. And I want to tell you something no one told me when I was there: the dark is not the end. It feels like the end. It senses like the end. But it isn't.

And I know its different faces. There is the dark that comes with noise: the crying that won't stop, the panic that squeezes the chest, the thoughts that spin in circles without stopping, the breath that gets

caught, the body that trembles. That darkness is visible. The people around you notice. They worry. They take you to the doctor. They try to help, even when they don't know how.

But there is another darkness, more silent and, for that reason, more dangerous. It's the darkness that disguises itself as normality. The woman who keeps functioning, who goes to work, who cares for her children, who smiles when she needs to, and who inside is slowly dying. Who puts her head on the pillow at night and feels a weight so great that she wonders how she will endure another day. Who no longer feels joy at anything, the food has no flavor, the laughter of children that once lit her up now seems to arrive from very far away, from a place she can no longer access.

This silent darkness is the one that worries me most. Because no one sees it. Because those who live it are ashamed to show it. Because society tells us that being strong means not falling apart, and so we fall apart on the inside while on the outside everything seems to function. And when we finally fall (and one does fall, eventually, when the interior can no longer hold up the facade), everyone is surprised. "But she seemed so well." She wasn't. She was performing. And the performance used her last reserves.

If you are in this silent darkness, if you are reading these lines and thinking "this is me," I want you to know: I see you. I don't need you to prove that you suffer. I don't need you to explain why. I know you're there. And the fact that you're reading this book already tells me that some part of you, however small it may seem, is still searching. Still wants to find a path. Still hasn't given up.

Hold onto that part. Even if it's tiny. Even if it seems like a single thread. Because it's in that thread that the crossing begins.

And there is something more about the bottom of the well that I need to tell you, because nobody talks about this: the bottom of the well is not a fixed place. You don't arrive there and stay. There are days when you feel you're rising, that you can see a little light, that maybe it's getting better. And there are days when you fall again, and it seems that all the rising was an illusion, that you never left the bottom, that the bottom has no end.

This oscillation is normal. It is not a sign of failure. It's a sign that you are alive, that your organism is trying to find balance, that there is a part of you fighting, even when you don't feel that you're fighting. And I want you to know that the days you fall don't erase the days you rose. Every centimeter of rising is real. Gravity can pull you down, but the path you made remains made.

There are women who tell me: "I should be better by now." As if there were a deadline for suffering. As if pain had an expiry date. As if two months, or six months, or a year were enough time to reorganize everything that fell apart. The truth is there is no deadline. Every crossing has its own time. And your time is yours. It's not comparable with anyone else's.

What I can tell you, with the honesty of someone who was there, is that the bottom of the well is not the end of the story. It's the place where the story changes direction. Not because there's a button to press, but because at the bottom, when there's nowhere further to go, something happens. Something subtle, almost imperceptible: the gaze begins to turn upward. Not by will. Not by decision. By instinct. By survival. By that part of you that, even in the deepest darkness, refuses to go out.

This book is not a light that will take you out of the dark. It doesn't work that way. No one takes you out of the dark from the outside. The crossing is made from within, with support, with time, with care. What this book can do is be the hand that reaches out in the darkness and says: I am here. You are not alone. And there are those who have been where you are and found the way back.

And if you'll allow me, I want to share something personal. My bottom of the well came without warning. It didn't come after an obvious tragedy. It came in silence, like a tide rising at night. I woke up one day not knowing why I was continuing. I had my children. I had my work. I had people who loved me. And none of it was reaching me. Not because I didn't value it. Because something inside me had disconnected. As if the cord that connected me to life had come out of the socket and I didn't know how to plug it back in.

And the hardest thing wasn't the pain. The hardest thing was the shame of feeling pain without "a sufficient reason." The feeling that I had no right to my own suffering. That I should be grateful, and happy, and functional. And that the fact that I wasn't was my fault.

It wasn't. And if you're feeling the same thing, I want you to know: it's not your fault. Pain doesn't need justification to be real. It doesn't need a sufficiently dramatic story to deserve attention. It simply needs to exist. It needs to be there. And if it's there, it deserves to be cared for.

I'm not going to romanticize your suffering. I'm not going to tell you that "everything happens for a reason." I'm not going to wrap your pain in pretty paper and put a personal growth bow on it. That would be a violence.

What I will do is offer you two things. First, a different perspective on what you're living through, a perspective that comes from Transpersonal Psychology and that sees in crises something more than illness. Second, the honesty to tell you that this perspective doesn't replace professional help, that if you need medication you need medication, that if you need therapy you need therapy, and that there is no shame whatsoever in needing.

The two things can coexist. You can be in crisis and need clinical help. And at the same time, somewhere inside you, something may be reorganizing itself in a way you don't yet understand. The two things are not mutually exclusive. And it's about that coexistence that I want to talk with you.

Come. With care. At your own pace. And if at any point you feel this is too much, stop. Close the book. Take care of yourself. Come back when you're ready. There's no rush in the dark.

Because that is exactly what this book asks of you: go slowly. Don't push yourself. Respect your state. I'm not going to ask you to be strong. You already are, more than you know. I'm not going to ask you to have hope. Hope will come when it can. For now, it's enough that you are here. Reading. Breathing. Giving yourself the chance to hear another perspective on what you're living through.

And I want you to know, before we begin, that this book was written with special care. Every word was weighed. Every idea was checked. Because I know that someone in the dark is vulnerable, and vulnerability deserves protection, not exploitation. I will not use your pain to sell you promises. I will not wrap it in beautiful language to make it more palatable. I will treat it with the seriousness it deserves. And if, in the end, you feel these pages accompanied you, even for a moment, even for a paragraph, that will be more than enough.

2. Two readings of crisis: illness and passage

When someone enters a crisis, the world around them tends to do one immediate thing: classify. Diagnose. Give it a name. "It's depression." "It's burnout." "It's anxiety." "It's a panic attack." And this classification, however useful it may be (and it is useful, in many cases it's essential), has a side effect: it reduces the experience to a pathology. To something that is wrong. To a malfunction that needs to be repaired.

And in many cases, that's exactly what it is. Depression is real. Clinical anxiety is real. Burnout is real. These are conditions that need treatment, support, often medication. I'm not questioning this. I'm not suggesting replacing the doctor with a guru, antidepressants with meditation, therapy with faith. That would be irresponsible and dangerous.

But I want to open a door to another reading. A reading that doesn't replace the first, it complements it. A reading that comes from a long tradition, present in different cultures and eras, and that Transpersonal Psychology has recovered and brought into the scientific field: the possibility that certain crises are not only malfunctions. They are transformations.

The idea is this: there are crises that are genuinely pathological, that result from biochemical imbalances, unprocessed trauma, conditions that require clinical intervention. And there are crises that, though they may look the same from the outside (the symptoms can be similar: isolation, weeping, loss of meaning, exhaustion, depersonalization), have a different nature. They are growth crises. Crises in which something in the psyche is trying to reorganize itself, to go deeper, to include dimensions of experience that until then were ignored.

Stanislav Grof, one of the founders of Transpersonal Psychology, called them "spiritual emergencies." The name can seem esoteric, but the concept is simpler than it sounds: it's the idea that certain states of profound crisis are transformation processes that, if accompanied with care (and not simply suppressed), can lead to a deeper, more integrated, more healthy psychological reorganization.

The difference between a spiritual emergency and a pathological crisis isn't always clear. And that's why professional accompaniment is fundamental. It's not up to you, alone, to make that distinction. It belongs to qualified professionals, attentive both to the clinical dimension and the existential dimension of your experience.

But there is something you can take from this perspective, even without making that distinction alone: the possibility that what you are living, however painful, may have a dimension of meaning that isn't yet visible. Not in the sense of "it was for your good." That is a cruel phrase that helps no one in the middle of pain. But in the sense that, within the chaos, something may be being born. Something that doesn't yet have a form. Something that needs the dark in order to germinate, the way a seed needs the earth.

Christian mysticism has a name for this: the dark night of the soul. St. John of the Cross described it as a period when God seems absent, faith seems empty, and the soul is in the deepest abandonment. But, he said, it is precisely in that abandonment that the most profound transformation happens. Not despite the darkness. Through it.

You don't need to be religious for this image to make sense. You don't need to believe in God to recognize that there are processes in the interior life that follow a different logic from the logic of day. Processes that aren't measured by results. Processes that can't be accelerated by effort. Processes that ask for surrender, not control.

Carl Jung's psychology speaks of something similar: the descent into the unconscious. The plunge into the depths of the psyche, where the contents that were excluded, repressed, forgotten reside. Jung saw this

plunge not as illness, but as an essential part of the individuation process, the path to becoming who we truly are. And he said that this path frequently begins with a crisis. With a loss of meaning. With a collapse of the ego. With the darkness.

I want to be very clear: I'm not saying every crisis is a "spiritual emergency." I'm not saying suffering is good. I'm not saying you should embrace the pain and be grateful for it. I'm saying there are two possible readings for what you're living, and both deserve attention. The clinical reading says: something needs treatment. The transpersonal reading says: something may be trying to be born. And both can be true at the same time.

I know a woman who went through this. I'll call her Marta. Marta had a crisis at forty-three. Apparently out of nowhere. She had a job, a husband, two teenage children, a life that, from the outside, worked. She began to feel a deep anxiety, with no apparent cause. Then came the panic attacks. Then insomnia. Then a sadness so dense she felt the air around her had grown heavier.

She went to the doctor. The doctor prescribed medication. And the medication helped, in part. It took the sharpest edge off the anxiety, allowed her to sleep a little. But Marta felt there was something beneath

the symptoms that the medication didn't touch. Something that was asking for attention, that wanted to be heard, that wouldn't go quiet.

It was then that she sought a therapist with transpersonal training. And that therapist said something to Marta that she never forgot: "Your crisis can be real and painful and need treatment. And at the same time, it may be trying to tell you something. The two things are not mutually exclusive."

Marta didn't stop the medication. She didn't stop clinical support. But she began, at the same time, to look at the crisis as something more than a malfunction. And what she found beneath the symptoms was something that came from very far back: an entire life built from what others expected of her, never from what she was. The crisis wasn't the problem. The crisis was the voice of everything she had silenced saying: enough.

I'm not telling this story to give you easy hope. I'm telling it to show you that the two readings can coexist. That you can treat the symptoms and, at the same time, listen to what they're trying to tell you.

What changes when you embrace both readings is not the pain. The pain is the same. What changes is your relationship with the pain. Because if the pain is only malfunction, the only response is to fix it. But

if the pain can also be a passage, then in addition to caring for yourself (and you must care, always), you can also ask: what does this passage want from me? What is trying to be born here, in this darkness?

Not to justify the suffering. To not waste it.

And I want to explore this idea of passage further, because it has nuances that matter.

A passage is not a flat road. A passage is, by definition, the crossing from one place to another. And between the two places there is difficult terrain: mountains, rivers, darkness, uncertainty. No one crosses a passage without effort. No one reaches the other side without having gotten lost along the way, at least once. And no one should have to make it alone, though many of us try.

Our culture has little tolerance for passages. It wants quick results. It wants immediate solutions. It wants a diagnosis and a treatment and a recovery timeline. "How long until you're better?" This is the question you hear, implicit or explicit, from those around you. And behind the question is an intolerance: suffering makes people uncomfortable. Not only those who suffer. Those who witness it too.

And so there is pressure to leave the darkness quickly. To "move forward." To "turn the page." To "think positive." And each of these phrases, however well-intentioned, is a form of subtle violence. Because it says: your darkness is not acceptable. Hurry up and get out of it.

But true passages have their own time. They don't hurry. They don't respond to deadlines. A woman who is reconfiguring her relationship with the world, who is letting one way of being die so that another can be born, needs the time she needs. And that time is sacred. Not in the religious sense. In the sense that it is non-negotiable.

The most courageous thing you can do, in the middle of a passage, is refuse to rush it. To say, with all your vulnerability: "I am crossing. I haven't arrived yet. And I don't know when I will. But I am walking."

There are ancient cultures that understood this. That had rites of passage, sacred spaces where the person in transition was welcomed, protected, cared for, while the process did its work. We lost those rituals. We were left without space for transformation. And so, when transformation comes (and it does come, because life demands it), we are alone, without a map, without a net, without permission.

This book cannot be the ritual your culture denied you. But it can be a recognition: what you are living deserves respect. Deserves time. Deserves care. Deserves to be treated for what it is: a passage, not a malfunction.

And there is an aspect of passages that few people mention: the loneliness. Not the loneliness of being physically alone (though that happens too). The loneliness of feeling that no one understands what you're living through. That no one sees what you see. That you're in a place so deep and so strange that the words you have can't describe it, and the words others use don't reach where you are.

That loneliness may be the most painful part of the passage. More than the pain itself. Because shared pain is bearable. Pain alone can seem unbearable. And in the darkness, the tendency is to isolate ourselves, to hide, to put on a mask and say "I'm fine" when people ask, because it's easier than trying to explain something for which there are no words.

But I want you to know: your loneliness, however real it may be, is an illusion of the dark. You are not alone. There are women at this very moment, all over the world, living versions of your crossing. Feeling your pain. Asking your questions. Lying down at night with the same

weight in their chest. You don't know them. But they exist. And the fact that they exist makes your crossing a little less solitary, even if only in theory.

And there are those who have already crossed. There are women who were where you are, who felt what you feel, who thought they would never get out, and who got out. Not unscathed. Transformed. And those women (myself among them) carry a certainty that no one else can have: the certainty that one does cross. Not because it's easy. Because if you are human enough to descend to the bottom, you are human enough to rise.

3. What Transpersonal Psychology sees in crises

Transpersonal Psychology is not an alternative psychology. It's an inclusive psychology. It includes what conventional psychology already knows (the ego, defense mechanisms, trauma, neurochemistry) and adds a dimension: the dimension that goes beyond the personal. The "trans" in transpersonal.

This dimension is not mystical. It is simply the recognition that a human being is not exhausted by the ego. That there are experiences (of connection, of meaning, of presence, of dissolution of the self) that are real, that are frequent, and that conventional psychology doesn't always know what to do with.

In crises, this dimension becomes particularly relevant. Because many deep crises are not only crises of the ego (though the ego is in crisis). They are crises of the whole system. They are moments when the way the person was organized ceases to work, when the narrative that sustained the identity crumbles, when the "self I thought I was" reveals itself as insufficient.

And when that structure falls, what appears can be terrifying. Because what appears is the unknown. What had no form. What was beneath everything you built, everything you learned to be.

Transpersonal Psychology sees in this moment not a catastrophe (though it feels like one), but an opportunity for reorganization. It's what some authors call "positive disintegration": the collapse of a more rigid structure so that a broader, more flexible, more integrated structure can emerge.

Roberto Assagioli, the creator of psychosynthesis (a transpersonal approach), described this process as a crisis of transformation: the lower self (the limited ego, with its defenses and its fears) needs to partially dissolve so that the higher self (broader, more integrated, more connected to the whole) can emerge. The dissolution is the crisis. The emergence is what comes after. But between one and the other, there is a dark corridor where it seems you're losing everything. And in a certain sense, you are: you're losing the version of yourself that no longer serves. And losing, even when what you lose is limitation, hurts. It hurts because it's familiar. It hurts because it's yours. It hurts because it's the only you you've ever known.

Think of an old house that no longer serves. The walls are too narrow, the ceiling too low, the rooms no longer correspond to the life you live. You can patch. You can paint. You can put up new curtains and pretend it serves. Or you can let certain walls fall so that the house can be rebuilt with more space, more light, more air. The falling of the walls is frightening. You live temporarily without a roof. But what comes after is larger than what was there before.

This is the transpersonal vision of crisis: not the house collapsing from a defect. The house collapsing because you have grown and it no longer fits. The problem isn't you. The problem is the structure. And the structure needs to change.

But (and this but is fundamental) reconstruction isn't done alone. Reconstruction needs support. It needs someone to hold the beams with you while the new is built. It needs a safe space where you can collapse without danger. It needs professionals who know the difference between a house that needs controlled demolition and a house that's on fire and needs firefighters.

That is why I insist: seek help. Not as an alternative to this understanding. As a complement. Transpersonal understanding gives you a framework. Professional support gives you the net.

There are women who tell me that, during their deepest crises, they had strange experiences. Vivid dreams, sensations in the body they couldn't explain, an amplified sensitivity that made them feel everything with an almost unbearable intensity. Some felt outside their body. Some felt presences. Some had memories that didn't seem like theirs. And the reaction of the world around them was, almost always, the same: you're going mad.

But they weren't. They were in transit. The system was reorganizing itself, and during the reorganization, the habitual boundaries of the ego became more permeable. Contents that are normally stored (memories, emotions, sensations) came to the surface because the barriers containing them had given way.

This is not madness. It's process. But it needs to be accompanied, because without accompaniment, the process can become overwhelming. With accompaniment (a therapist who understands both the clinical and the transpersonal dimension), the process can be integrated. And the person who emerges on the other side is, frequently, more whole than the one who went in.

Not necessarily happier. Not necessarily lighter. But more true. More in contact with themselves. More capable of living with the complexity of human experience without needing to simplify it.

And there is something that Transpersonal Psychology underlines that conventional psychology doesn't always contemplate: the dimension of the sacred in crisis. Not sacred in the religious sense (though for some people, crisis has a religious dimension). Sacred in the sense that certain sufferings touch something profoundly human, something that goes beyond individual biography, something that connects us to all human experience of pain and transformation across the centuries.

When a woman loses a child, her suffering is personal and unique. But it also touches something universal: the pain of all the mothers who have lost children throughout history. When someone crosses a dark night of the soul, their experience is singular. But it echoes with all the dark nights that have ever been crossed. And there is, in that resonance, something that can be a source of strength. Not cheap consolation ("you're not alone," said as a cliché). But deep recognition: what you're living is human. Profoundly, radically human. And generations of women and men have gone through something similar and found the path.

This doesn't diminish your pain. It doesn't make it easier. But it situates it. It gives it a ground. It takes it out of the isolation of "only I suffer like this" and places it in a vaster landscape, where suffering is not

aberration, it's part of the experience of being alive. And knowing that it belongs, that it's part of things, that it's human, can make the difference between despair and crossing.

There is a concept in Transpersonal Psychology that illustrates this dynamic well: the concept of symbolic death. Not literal death, of course. But the death of a way of being. The death of the "self" you have built until now: the self that defined itself by certain roles, certain beliefs, certain certainties. When that self dies (and in certain crises, it truly does die, collapses irreversibly), what remains is a terrifying void. Because the new self hasn't been born yet. You are in the interval. In the space between who you were and who you will be. And that space is unbearable, because human beings were not made for the absence of identity.

But it is precisely in that space that transformation happens. Not despite the symbolic death. Through it. What died had to die so that something vaster could be born. The shell broke so the creature could emerge. The chrysalis is not the caterpillar's illness. It's the path to wings.

I know this image can seem too beautiful for what you're feeling. In the middle of pain, no one wants to hear about wings. They want the pain to stop. And I respect that deeply. I'm not saying your pain is beautiful. I'm saying your pain may have a dimension you haven't yet seen. That it

may be taking you somewhere, even when everything tells you you're lost. And keeping that possibility open (not as blind faith, but as genuine openness) can help you bear what otherwise seems unbearable.

I also want to talk about something I observe frequently and that Transpersonal Psychology names clearly: crisis as a moment of integration. Many women I accompany discover, in the course of their crisis, that there are parts of themselves that were excluded throughout life. The anger they never allowed themselves to feel. The sadness they pushed under the rug. The inner child who was told to be quiet. The sexuality that was repressed. The creativity that was abandoned. The spirituality that was ridiculed. These excluded parts don't disappear. They stay in the subsoil of the psyche, exerting pressure. And when the pressure is too great, the surface gives way. And everything comes to the surface.

Crisis, in this perspective, is the moment when the excluded parts demand inclusion. It's not a malfunction. It's a calling. The psychic system is saying: I can no longer function without integrating what was excluded. And that process of integration is painful, chaotic, frightening. But on the other side is a more whole person, more true, more capable of living with the totality of their experience.

4. What helps in the crossing

If you are in the dark, I want to offer you some things that can help. They are not techniques. They are not steps. They are orientations, like signals on a night road. They don't replace a guide. But they indicate direction.

First: allow yourself to be in the dark.

This seems contradictory. You're suffering and I'm telling you to allow yourself to suffer? Yes. Because most of the additional suffering you feel doesn't come from the darkness itself. It comes from fighting against it. It comes from "I should be better." It comes from "that's enough." It comes from "others can do it, why can't I?" It comes from the shame of being where you are.

The dark is not the enemy. Resistance to the dark is what increases the pain. I'm not asking you to like it. I'm asking you to stop fighting against it. To stop blaming yourself for being there. To allow yourself to feel what you feel without the extra layer of judgment.

"I am in the dark. And I'm doing what I can." Saying this to yourself, with honesty and without heroism, already relieves something.

There is a practice that, in the middle of everything, can help: instead of trying to change what you feel, try simply naming it. "Right now I feel weight in my chest." "Right now I feel fear." "Right now I feel a wish to disappear." Not to analyze. Not to solve. Simply to recognize. Giving a name to what you feel, even when what you feel is terrible, creates a small distance between you and the emotion. You stop being the pain and become someone who feels pain. It seems like the same thing. But it isn't. The difference is immense. Because someone who feels pain can ask for help. Can take care of themselves. Can decide. Pure pain, with no subject, can do nothing.

This small naming practice is not a self-help technique. It's neuroscience. When you name an emotion, the amygdala (the part of the brain responsible for the fear and alarm response) calms down. Literally. Naming the emotion activates the prefrontal cortex, which is the part of the brain capable of regulating, contextualizing, breathing. It's not magic. It's biology. And in the dark, any tool that helps you breathe better is precious.

Second: don't stay alone.

The dark has a trap: it makes you believe that no one understands you. That no one wants to know. That you're a burden. That it's better to isolate yourself, not to bother anyone, not to show your pain. That voice is

not yours. It's the voice of the dark. And it lies.

There are people who can accompany you. Mental health professionals, first of all. But also friends who know how to be quiet with you. Family members who don't need to fix you. Someone who simply sits beside you and says: I'm here. I don't need you to be well. I'm here.

I know finding these people can seem impossible. We live in a culture of "are you better?" where everyone wants other people's suffering to resolve itself quickly. Few people know how to be with another person's pain without trying to fix it. Few people can bear the discomfort of seeing someone they love suffering without saying "think positive" or "it could be worse." But these people exist. Sometimes they're closer than you think. Sometimes they're the quiet friend who doesn't call every day but who, when you call, is there. Sometimes they're the neighbor who brings soup without asking why. Sometimes they're professionals who have made listening their vocation.

If you don't have anyone like that, seek a professional. A psychologist, a psychotherapist. Not tomorrow. Today. Because the dark becomes more bearable when you're not alone in it.

And there is something I need to say about the shame of asking for help, especially professional help. Many women feel that going to a psychologist is a sign of failure. That they "can't manage." That they are "weaker than others." I want to dismantle this with all the clarity I have: going to a psychologist is as normal as going to the dentist when you have a toothache. Your mind, your emotional world, your interior, deserves the same care you give your body. It's not a luxury. It's not weakness. It's pure emotional intelligence.

Third: take care of your body.

In the dark, the body is often the first to be abandoned. You stop eating well, or you overeat. You stop sleeping, or you sleep too much. You stop moving. The body becomes an object you merely carry around, rather than a place where you live.

But the body is your ground. It's the only thing that is always with you, always here, always now. And when you care for it (with sleep, with food, with movement, even small movements, even slow ones), you are taking care of the foundation on which the crossing is made.

I'm not telling you to go to the gym. I'm telling you to walk ten minutes in the sun, if you can. To drink water. To eat something that nourishes you. To take a warm bath. Small things. Basic things. Things that in the

dark seem enormous, but that make a difference.

Fourth: don't isolate yourself from beauty.

This may seem strange. You're suffering and I'm talking about beauty?

Yes. Because beauty is one of the few things that cuts through the dark.

A piece of music, a tree, the face of someone you love, the light at the end of the afternoon. Beauty doesn't solve the suffering. But it reminds you that the world is larger than your pain. And that reminder, sometimes, is enough to keep breathing.

You don't need to go looking for beauty. It's close. It's in the sound of rain, the smell of coffee, the touch of a hand. It's in the things the dark makes you forget exist, but that exist, that keep existing, waiting for you to notice them.

There is a woman who told me that, during the darkest phase of her life, there was one thing that kept her: every morning when she woke (on the days she could get up), she went to the window and looked at a tree in the yard. Any old tree. Nothing special. But she looked at it for two or three minutes. And in those minutes, something quieted inside her. The pain didn't disappear. Happiness didn't come. But there was a moment of contact with something real, something alive, something that existed beyond her suffering. And that moment was enough to begin the day.

Beauty doesn't cure you. But it anchors you. It reminds you that the world continues, that life continues, that there are beautiful things even when everything inside you is in ruins. And that reminder, however small it may seem, matters. Because in the dark, the tendency is to feel the whole world has gone dark. But it hasn't. The darkness is inside you. Out there, the sun keeps rising, the trees keep growing, children keep laughing. And when you allow yourself to see that, even for moments, the interior darkness becomes a little less absolute.

Fifth: accept that the process is not linear.

There will be better days. And then there will be terrible days again. And the tendency is to think you've gone back to the beginning, that all the progress was lost, that you'll never get out of there. But that's not how the crossing works. The crossing works in a spiral: you pass through the same place more than once, but each time you pass, you are a little higher. It seems the same. But it isn't. You are no longer the same person who passed through here last time.

A setback is not failure. It's part of the path. And if you accept this (not with resignation, but with realism), bad days stop being proof that you've failed and become moments of crossing that demand more patience, more care, more tenderness toward yourself.

Sixth: trust time.

The darkness is not eternal. It seems eternal. Every day seems like an entire lifetime. Every night seems to have no end. But the darkness passes. Not suddenly. Not like someone switching on a light. Gradually, like dawn. First a shade. Then another. Then a contour. Then a shape. And one day you realize you can see again. Not everything. But enough.

I remember a woman who told me, a year after the deepest crisis of her life: "I look back and I don't know how I survived. But I know there was a moment when I decided to stay. Not because I knew it would get better. Not because I had hope. But because I decided I was going to stay to see. And I stayed. And now I see." That decision to stay, when everything inside you screams to give up, is perhaps the most courageous act a human being can practice. If you're doing it now, I want you to know that I recognize your courage. Even if no one else sees it.

Time doesn't heal by itself. Time is the space where healing happens, if you give it the right conditions. And the conditions are: support, care, presence, and the courage not to flee.

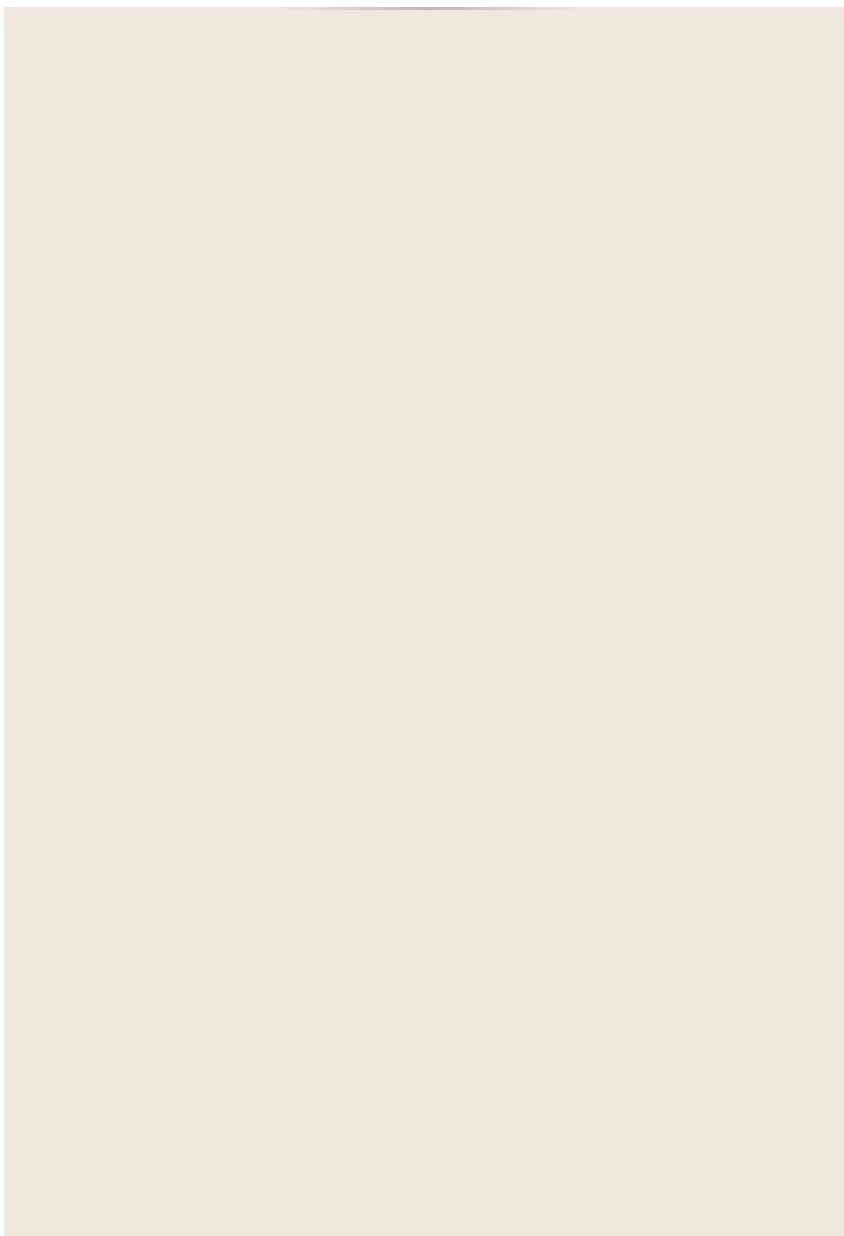
Seventh: let others care for you.

I know. You're the one who takes care. You're the one who holds things together. You're the one who solves problems. You're the one who's always there for everyone. And the idea of someone caring for you is, for many women, more uncomfortable than the pain itself. Because receiving care requires vulnerability. And vulnerability is the thing you avoid most.

But in the dark, your capacity to care for yourself is compromised. It's like trying to swim when you're drowning: the movements that normally keep you afloat no longer work. And in that moment, the most intelligent, most courageous, most wise thing you can do is let someone throw you a lifeline. That's not weakness. That's survival.

Let people bring you food. Let them care for your children for an afternoon. Let them hold you without asking anything in return. Let them ask questions and accept that you don't have answers. Let the therapy do its work, even when it seems like it isn't working.

Healing is not a solitary act. It's a relational act. We heal in relation. With others, with the world, and eventually with ourselves. But the relationship with others comes first, because in the dark, the relationship with yourself is temporarily inaccessible. And others can be the bridge that takes you back to yourself.



5. When to seek help

This chapter is direct. Because there are things that don't need prose. They need clarity. And I need to be honest with you about something: however useful this book may be as a perspective, there are situations where a book is not enough. There are situations where you need someone of flesh and blood, with training, with experience, sitting in front of you (or on the other end of the phone), caring for you.

We live in a culture that celebrates self-sufficiency. "I can manage alone." "I don't want to be a bother." "Others have it worse." These phrases, which so many of us repeat like mantras, are traps. Because they prevent us from asking for what we need. And asking for help, when you're in the dark, is not weakness. It's the purest form of caring for yourself.

There are women who come to me after spending months, sometimes years, trying to resolve alone something that needed professional support. Who read all the books, did all the exercises, meditated, prayed, tried everything except the simplest and most difficult thing: asking for help. And when they finally ask, when they finally sit in front of some-

one who knows how to listen to them, they feel a mixture of relief and anger. Relief because they're finally not alone. Anger because they lost so much time trying to be strong.

Don't waste that time. You deserve help. Your children deserve a mother who takes care of herself. Your body deserves attention. Your mind deserves qualified company. And the first step can be as simple as picking up the phone and making an appointment. Just that. You don't need to know what to say when you get there. You don't need to have the answers. The professional is there to help you find them.

Seek professional help if:

You feel you can't go on. If the weight is so great that the idea of another day seems unbearable. If you're thinking of giving up, of disappearing, of harming yourself. Don't wait. Don't minimize. Don't convince yourself "it'll pass tomorrow." Call now. A support line, a doctor, the emergency services. Your life matters more than anything you're feeling in this moment.

You're unable to function. If you can't get up, if you can't take care of yourself or your children, if your body has stopped functioning in a way you can't control. This is not weakness. This is your body asking for help. Listen to it.

Symptoms persist for more than two weeks. If deep sadness, loss of pleasure, changes in sleep and appetite, exhaustion without physical cause, continue day after day without improvement. This can be clinical depression, and clinical depression needs treatment. It's not a matter of willpower. It's a matter of health.

You feel you're losing contact with reality. If you're having experiences that frighten you, if you don't know what is real and what isn't, if the world around you seems unreal. Seek help immediately. There are professionals prepared to accompany you through this.

Someone who loves you is worried about you. Sometimes others see what we can't see ourselves. If someone you trust has said "I'm worried about you," listen. Not as a criticism. As an act of love.

There is no shame at all in needing help. The strongest people I know are those who had the courage to say "I can't do this alone." And they received help. And they crossed. And they are here.

6. The crossing

If you've made it this far, if you've read these pages in the middle of your darkness, I want you to know one thing: I am with you. Not only in words. In the shared experience of someone who knows what it is to be at the bottom and, one day, see the first light.

What this book offered you was a perspective. Not a cure. Not a recipe. Not a promise that everything will be fine (because that promise would be a lie, and you deserve more than lies). It offered you the idea that darkness can have more dimensions than what first appears. That crisis, beyond suffering, can contain a seed of transformation. That you, in the middle of everything you are living, may be becoming more than you were.

But that transformation is not done alone. It's not done by reading books. It's not done with good intentions. It's done with support, with accompaniment, with a safe space where you can be vulnerable without danger.

The Escola dos Véus was created for that: for the moments when you need more than understanding. For the moments when you need presence, guidance, someone who walks with you in the dark without

trying to turn on the light before the time is right. Not as a substitute for clinical help, but as a complement. As the space where, with the safety net of professional accompaniment, you can look at the darkness and ask: what is here for me? Find that space at escoladosveus.space.

And if there is a part of your crossing that asks for expression, that asks you to create, that asks you to bring out what is inside, Infonte is a space where creativity becomes a tool for reconnection. Because sometimes, what can't be said in words can be drawn, written, sung, shaped. At infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

But the first step, before any guided crossing, is this: take care of yourself. Seek help if you need it. Give yourself permission to be where you are. And remember, even in the moments when it seems impossible, that the darkness is not forever.

I want to leave you with an image. Not as consolation, but as truth.

Seeds germinate in the dark. Not despite the dark. In the dark. It is there, beneath the earth, without light, without warmth, without anyone watching, that life organizes itself. That the shell breaks. That the first root seeks the ground. That the first shoot seeks the air. No one sees this process. No one applauds it. It happens in silence, in the dark, without witnesses.

You may be in that place now. Beneath the earth. In the silence. In the dark. And it may not seem like anything is happening. It may seem like you're only suffering, only holding on, only surviving. But perhaps, inside, where you can't see, something is germinating. Something that doesn't yet have a name, that doesn't yet have a form, but that is real.

The dawn is not spectacular. It doesn't come with trumpets or fireworks. It comes slowly. It comes in silence. It comes with a slightly lighter shade on the horizon, so subtle that at first you think you're imagining it. But you're not. It's real. And it's for you.

Stay. Breathe. Ask for help. And trust, even if by a single thread, that the darkness is not the end of the story. It's the place where the story transforms.

With all the care in the world, *Vivianne*

This material is for self-knowledge and personal reflection. It does not constitute therapeutic, psychological, or medical advice, nor does it replace the support of qualified professionals. In situations of crisis, acute

suffering, suicidal ideation, or loss of contact with reality, seek immediate professional help. In Portugal: SNS 24 (808 24 24 24), SOS Voz Amiga (213 544 545). Don't face the dark alone.

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